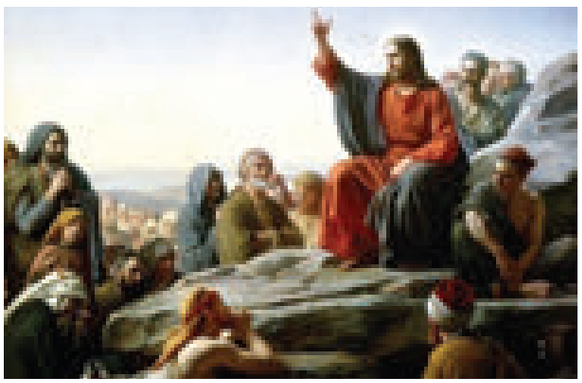


Buddha (China)

Han emperors found it extremely difficult to control the big land owners. So after some decades of consolidation, China saw the emergence of several rival kingdoms marked by civil wars in north China. People abandoned their homes and farms, and fled from there to the Yangtze region and beyond. The period after Han ruled witnessed political instability across the country.

5.4 Rise of Christianity

After a brief period of glory in the days of David and Solomon, the Jewish people had a great fall and experienced extreme hardship. While spreading out all over the Roman Empire and elsewhere, they hoped that a Messiah would arrive to restore their pristine glory. Initially they laid much hopes on Jesus. Jesus was against the rich and the hypocrites, and condemned certain observances and ceremonials. This was not to the liking of the priests, who turned against Jesus and handed him over to the Roman Governor Pontius Pilate. Looked upon as a political rebel by the Roman authorities, Jesus was tried and crucified.



Jesus addressing his followers

After Jesus's crucifixion, St Paul started spreading the Christian doctrine. Paul succeeded in his effort and Christianity gradually spread. Romans were prepared to tolerate Christianity. But the refusal of the Christians to pay respect to the Emperor's image was viewed as political treason. It led to the persecution of Christians. Their property was confiscated and they were thrown to the lions. Yet the Roman Empire did not succeed in suppressing Christianity. One of the Roman emperors Constantine himself became a Christian. Christianity thus became the official religion of the Empire.

St. Sophia Cathedral



St. Sophia Cathedral was built in mid-sixth century AD (CE) The most magnificent building in Europe at that time, it was known for its innovative architectural techniques. This Cathedral was turned into a mosque by the Ottoman Turks when they captured Constantinople.

5.5 Byzantium

The Byzantine emperors, who ruled from the city of Constantinople for about 1,000 years, called themselves Romans. But their language was Greek. The splendour of Constantinople with its luxurious royal palaces, its libraries, its scholars familiar with the writings of Greeks and Romans and its fascinating St. Sophia Cathedral are the legacies they have left behind.

However, in terms of development of science and technology, there was no progress during this period. The economies of the Empire's provinces were in the hands of large local landowners. The small peasants always lived on the edge of poverty. The fundamental weakness of Byzantine Civilisation stood exposed when the participants of Fourth Crusade pillaged it and ruled it. The tottering empire finally fell to the Ottoman Turks in 1453.

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